

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

Lexicon 1

How to make a word: An intro to the lexicon for conlangers



March 2020

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Assignment

Your assignment for this week is (obviously) to make a few lexemes in your conlang. I am under the assumption that most of you have a good idea of what your phonology looks like. If not, you can still test out some ideas during this assignment.

You will create ten lexemes (I recommend creating one or two every day this week to space it out). These ten lexemes must each come with six things:

- the lexeme (obviously)
- the pronunciation
- the part of speech (noun, verb, adjective, etc.)
- the sense(s)
- usage of the lexeme in a sentence (if your conlang is not ready yet, then you can just insert the word into an English sentence.)
- a photo representing the lexeme, or something similar (this can be from an image search or a drawing of your own creation)

Each word has its own prompt to help you apply some of the concepts in this week's lesson.

Prompt 1

A speaker of your conlang is hungry. Where can she find food?

The lexeme should be an unbound morpheme.

Prompt 2

A young child has hurt himself playing a game. What game was it?

This lexeme should be a non-compositional compound.

Prompt 3

Your speaker's friends are joking about his fear of something. What is he afraid of?

This lexeme should have at least two senses ~~for the puns~~.

Prompt 4

A toddler incorrectly identifies an animal. What did she mistake it for?

Your example sentence should explain to the toddler what the lexeme is not referring to.

Prompt 5

An elderly speaker uses one of these every day. What is it?

This lexeme should be a homophone with another lexeme in this assignment.

Prompt 6

Two friends are having an argument. What is it about?

This lexeme should have a vague sense.

Prompt 7

This lexeme is a synonym of another lexeme in this assignment.

Give it a different connotative meaning.

Prompt 8

A speaker doesn't like how a certain fabric feels. What does it feel like?
This lexeme should have at least four somewhat related senses.

Prompt 9

A speaker has died.
This lexeme should be an idiom about death.

Prompt 10

Freestyle. Do whatever you want. I've run out of ideas.